THE STAR LANES BLUEPRINT

Eleven systems. *One business.*

A diagnostic of why your operating system is costing you time, money, and exit value — and what it takes to fix it.

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DATE

April 2026

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CONTENTS

Five blocks. *One arc.*

§ 00 **Executive Summary** — START →
What I found, what it costs, what I recommend.

§ A **The Systems Map** — DIAGNOSIS
Why eleven systems can't agree on one business.

§ B **The Reconciliation Tax** — COST
What it costs you, this year and next.

§ C **The Operating Layer** — ANSWER
The shape of the fix.

§ D **Three Paths Forward** — CHOICE
Pick the one that matches where Star Lanes actually is.

§ E **The Exit Math** — UPSIDE
$36,000 to protect a $3.6M swing.

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY / READ THIS FIRST

Star Lanes is not a broken business. It's a strong business running on a *broken operating system* — and that's costing you on two fronts.

THE DIAGNOSIS

11

Disconnected systems claiming five different versions of the truth.

Square, Triple Seat, Embed, Conqueror, Rex, 501 Fund, and the rest each own a piece of the business but none of them agree on the same customer, the same revenue, or the same event. The full map is in Block A.

THE VISIBLE COST

$20,800

Per year of human reconciliation work, the day OSU opens.

Five hours a week, $40/hr, two locations — this is just the labor tax of journal entries your sister-in-law is doing by hand because Square doesn't understand event deposits. The math is shown in Block B.

THE FIX

1

Read-only operating layer above your existing systems.

Don't replace Square. Don't replace Triple Seat. Build a thin layer that listens, normalizes, and reports — one customer record, one revenue ledger, one source of truth. Architecture in Block C, three implementation paths in Block D.

THE REAL NUMBER

$3.6M

Valuation swing at the closing table when you sell at three units.

A one-turn multiple swing on $3.6M of EBITDA. Clean books and a transferable operating system get you 5×. Dirty books get you 4×. That's a clean 100× return on a $36K build. The exit math is in Block E.

THE THREE PATHS

Three real options for how much of the operating system to fix right now — *not three flavors of the same project.*

PATH 01

The Proof

$5,000

One bleed fixed in 2 weeks. See the layer work before scaling.

PATH 02

The Fix

$18,000

· 2 × $9K MONTHLY

Polaris running clean in 6–8 weeks. Every bleed in Block B addressed.

PATH 03

The Endgame

$36,000

· 3 × $12K MONTHLY

Built for OSU from day one. The 100× return on the exit-table math.

Read Block D for the full breakdown. Pick the one that matches where Star Lanes actually is — or push back if none of them fit.

Everything below this page is the work behind these four numbers — the diagnosis, the cost math, the architecture, and the industry data on multiples and exit valuations. Read what you want, in any order. **If you only have ten minutes, this page is the one that matters.**

§ A

Block A of E

DIAGNOSIS

The Systems *Map*

Why eleven systems can't agree on one business.

Star Lanes is not *one business* running on one system. It's *four businesses* — bowling, arcade, food & bar, and events — running on eleven systems that don't talk to each other.

This page maps every system Star Lanes uses today, what each one is responsible for, and where two or more systems claim ownership of the same fact about your business.

Every system on this page is good at its job individually. The problem isn't any one tool. The problem is the gap between them — and that gap is where your sister-in-law's nights, your reconciliation tax, and your loyalty program are getting eaten.

Read this as a diagnosis, not a sales deck. If anything below is wrong, tell me — I'd rather get it right than get it pretty.

§ 01

Five truths your business needs to know

Every operating decision you make depends on knowing one of these five things. Right now, no single system can answer all five — and several of them disagree.

TRUTH 01

Financial

What actually counted as revenue today, this week, this month?

TRUTH 02

Customer

Who walked in, what did they spend, and is it worth getting them back?

TRUTH 03

Event

What was sold, what was consumed, what's still owed?

TRUTH 04

Operational

What's booked, what's available, what's the team scheduled to do?

TRUTH 05

Marketing

Where did the lead come from, and which channels are actually paying off?

§ 02

The eleven systems

Each card shows what the system owns and which of the five truths it touches. Red dots mark systems where ownership overlaps with another system in a way that creates the reconciliation tax I'll quantify in the next section.

Square — POS · CARD

Food & beverage point of sale, card processing, future loyalty engine.

FINANCIAL · CUSTOMER

Embed — GAME CARDS

Arcade game card sales, kiosk transactions, redemption tracking.

FINANCIAL · CUSTOMER

Conqueror — BOWLING POS

Bowling lane management, scoring, lane-side ordering, time tracking.

FINANCIAL · OPERATIONAL

501 Fund — DARTS

Electronic dart board scoring and per-station billing on its own tablet.

FINANCIAL

Omni Arena — VR

Free-roam VR attraction. Standalone — no integration with the rest of the venue.

FINANCIAL

Triple Seat — EVENT CRM

Event sales pipeline, BEOs, deposits, lane-as-inventory holds.

EVENT · OPERATIONAL · CUSTOMER

Rex — ONLINE BOOKING

Public-facing lane reservation. Pulls availability from Triple Seat via API.

OPERATIONAL · CUSTOMER

Compeat → R365 — ACCOUNTING

Books of record. Compeat is being retired; R365 is the migration target.

FINANCIAL

Hot Schedules — STAFF

Today's scheduler and staff messaging — being retired this year.

OPERATIONAL

New HR / Sched — REPLACEMENT

Replacing Hot Schedules. Will need to connect to payroll and Square.

OPERATIONAL

Go High Level — MARKETING

Review responses, agency-built chatbot, marketing automation.

MARKETING · CUSTOMER

Eventective — LEAD SOURCE

Inbound corporate-event lead generation directory.

MARKETING

§ 03

Why this matters: one customer, four answers

The systems map looks busy on paper. The real cost shows up when you watch what happens to a single customer interaction. Here's a normal Friday night at Star Lanes.

CASE STUDY / 01

"A customer walks in, buys two beers at the bar, drops $40 on a game card, bowls a lane for an hour, and books a corporate event for next month with a $1,000 deposit."

/ ONE GUEST · ONE NIGHT · FOUR SYSTEMS · FOUR DIFFERENT TRUTHS

SYSTEM	WHAT IT RECORDS	TRUTH CLAIMED	STATUS
Square	Records the two beers as $18 in F&B revenue. Records the $1,000 event deposit as *realized revenue* the day it's collected.	FINANCIAL	HALF WRONG
Embed	Records the $40 game card sale as a separate transaction. No connection to the Square customer record from the same night.	CUSTOMER	BLIND
Conqueror	Records the lane time as bowling revenue in its own system. No tie to the bar tab or game card from the same guest.	FINANCIAL	BLIND
Triple Seat	Records the event booking and the $1,000 deposit as a future-dated liability, which is the correct accounting.	EVENT	CORRECT
Compeat / R365	Inherits whatever Square sent. Sister-in-law has to manually back the $1,000 out of revenue and reclassify it as deferred.	FINANCIAL	MANUAL FIX NEEDED

THE CUSTOMER SIDE

Four systems just saw the same person spend *$108 plus a $1,000 deposit* — and not one of them has a unified record of who that customer is.

THE ACCOUNTING SIDE

The books say revenue was *$1,000 higher* than it actually was, until someone reverses it by hand at month-end.

§ 04

What this is costing you

Three specific bleeds, ranked by dollar value at scale. The full ROI math is in Block B; these are the headline numbers.

BLEED · 01

The reconciliation tax

Your sister-in-law spends roughly five hours every week reconciling Square gross-vs-net, event deposits booked as revenue, and beverage-package consumption that has no native inventory comp button. Multiply by two locations once OSU opens.

→ ~$20K/YEAR AT TWO UNITS

BLEED · 02

The loyalty program you can't launch

Square Loyalty only sees Square spend. A guest who drops $200 on game cards, $80 on a bowling lane, and $40 at the bar registers as a $40 customer. The program will train your best customers around an incomplete view of their own value.

→ REPEAT-VISIT REVENUE, UNMEASURABLE

BLEED · 03

The unit-two multiplier

If unit one is messy, unit two isn't 2× messy — it's 4×. Cross-location loyalty, gift card liability, manager differences, local marketing attribution. And the reporting a future buyer wants to see at three units doesn't exist if the data is dirty at one.

→ ACQUISITION-READINESS RISK

• THE SHAPE OF THE FIX

You don't need to *replace* any of these systems. You need a thin layer *above* them.

Square is good at being Square. Triple Seat is good at being Triple Seat. The fix isn't another vendor trying to do all of it — that's the same trap you've been in with Diverted River for over a year.

The fix is a read-only operating layer that pulls from each system, gives every customer one identity, classifies every transaction the way your accountant actually books it, and produces one daily picture of the business that all eleven systems can agree on.

It starts read-only — meaning nothing in your production stack changes until I'm sure the layer is right. Then I connect it to R365, then to your

loyalty program, then to OSU when it opens.

This is what Block C, D, and E will lay out. What's on this page is the diagnosis. The next pages are the prescription.

§ B

Block B of E

COST

The Reconciliation *Tax*

What it costs you, this year and next.

Block A showed why the systems collide. Block B answers the only question that matters: *what is it costing you?*

Every time two systems disagree about the same fact, somebody has to fix it by hand. That somebody is your sister-in-law. The fix gets copied into a journal entry, a spreadsheet, an email — and the time it takes is invisible because it's already baked into how things have always run.

This page makes it visible. It puts a number on the bleed at one location, a number on the bleed at two locations, and one bigger number for what dirty data does to your three-unit endgame.

Every figure on this page is an estimate. The methodology is shown. If any of the inputs are wrong, the math redoes itself in five minutes — and we end up with a number you trust, not a number that sounds good.

/ THE TWO-UNIT BLEED

$20,800

per year of human reconciliation work, the day OSU opens.

SINGLE-UNIT COST: $10,400/YR · DOUBLES WHEN UNIT TWO OPENS · COMPOUNDS WHEN SYSTEMS MULTIPLY

§ 01

The four places the money is going

Each of these is a specific fix your accountant is making by hand right now because Square, Triple Seat, Embed, and Conqueror don't agree about what counts as revenue, what's a deposit, and what was consumed.

BLEED · 01

Event deposits booked as revenue

When a corporate group puts down $1,000 to hold a date, Square logs it as $1,000 in sales the day the card runs. Your books say it's a liability until the event happens.

Every deposit gets manually backed out at month-end and reclassified as deferred revenue. With ~30+ events per month, that's 30+ journal entries that should be one automated rule.

> *"Square actually processes that transaction but they count it as sales for us. We hold it as a liability. Square doesn't recognize that."*

TIME COST

~2 hrs

PER WEEK, PER LOCATION

BLEED · 02

Beverage packages with no inventory comp

When a corporate group prepays for an unlimited premium bar package, the bartender still has to ring every drink so liquor inventory stays accurate. Those rings inflate revenue a second time.

Micros had a one-button "inventory comp" that handled this cleanly. Square doesn't. So every event with a beverage package needs a manual reversal — and the bigger the event, the bigger the cleanup.

> *"On Micros we literally had a button. There's no way to do it in Square. So we're running this and my gross sales — it doesn't know, and I don't know."*

TIME COST

~1.5 hrs

PER WEEK, PER LOCATION

BLEED · 03

Cross-system sales reconciliation

Square reports gross. The books need net. Embed sells game cards as one transaction; the redemption inside the venue is another. Triple Seat tracks event packages on its own ledger. Each one is locally correct and globally incomplete.

Every week, somebody pulls four reports, lines up the numbers, and figures out which is the real one. That's not a spreadsheet job — that's interpretive work that has to happen before anything closes.

> *"We're constantly creating workarounds. We're adding numbers and subtracting numbers. It's almost archaic."*

TIME COST

~1 hr

PER WEEK, PER LOCATION

BLEED · 04

Triple Seat → Square → R365 mapping fixes

R365 inherits whatever Square sends it. If Square's categories are messy — and event packages, venue rentals, and bundled F&B make them messy — the mess gets copied straight into the books of record.

Mapping corrections get made on the R365 side, not the source side. Same fix, every period. The migration from Compeat to R365 is a chance to fix this once — or to inherit the workaround forever.

> *"There's a tremendous amount of work to get to the point where we actually can have it set properly, and Square is limited on the events side."*

TIME COST

~0.5 hr

PER WEEK, PER LOCATION

§ 02

The math, shown out loud

No black box. Here's exactly how the headline number gets to $20,800. If any of these inputs is off, the number redoes itself.

THE MATH / SHOWN

Five hours per week. Roughly $40 per hour fully loaded. Fifty-two weeks. Two locations once OSU opens.

INPUT	VALUE
Weekly reconciliation hours, per location	5.0 hrs
Loaded hourly cost (accountant time)	$40.00 / hr

INPUT	VALUE
Weeks per year	52
Annual cost — Polaris (today)	$10,400
Annual cost — OSU (when it opens)	$10,400
Two-location annual reconciliation tax	**$20,800**

ASSUMPTION / HOURS

Five hours weekly is the conservative read of what you described in our walkthrough — bigger event weeks run longer.

ASSUMPTION / RATE

$40/hr fully loaded is a reasonable estimate for an internal bookkeeping role with benefits in Columbus. Adjust if her real rate is different.

ASSUMPTION / SCALING

Unit two adds the same five-hour weekly burden, not less — separate POS instances, separate event books, separate reconciliations.

The bleed compounds. *It doesn't stay flat.*

Reconciliation work scales with system count, not headcount. As Star Lanes adds locations and adds tools, the manual fix-it work grows faster than revenue does.

TODAY / 1 LOCATION

$10,400

Per year. Polaris alone, current systems, current event volume.

OSU OPENS / 2 LOCATIONS

$20,800

Per year. Two locations, doubled work, no consolidated reporting yet.

YEAR 3 / 2 LOCATIONS

$25,000+

Loyalty + cross-location gift cards + R365 reporting drift add complexity.

3 LOCATIONS / ACQUISITION

Valuation hit

A buyer paying a multiple discounts dirty financials, not just labor cost.

THE NUMBER BEHIND THE NUMBER

The $20K is the *visible* cost. The bigger one shows up at the closing table.

You said the long-term play is three units, then sale. Buyers paying multiples on multi-unit hospitality don't just buy the venue. They buy the operating system — clean unit economics, repeatable financials, reporting they can audit, customer data they can own.

If the data is dirty when they show up, the multiple comes down. Not because of the $20K of accountant time — that's noise. Because every line item with a manual workaround is a question mark in diligence, and question marks discount valuations.

This is the real ROI of fixing the layer now. The $20K/year pays for the work. The exit math is what makes it the most important project on the calendar.

> *"Three units is what gets me acquirable."*

The Operating *Layer*

The shape of the fix.

Block A showed why the systems collide. Block B put a number on it. *This is what the fix actually looks like* — and what it isn't.

The instinct, when systems don't talk, is to find the one super-tool that does everything. You've been running that search for over a year — Diverted River, vendor demos, every booth at IAAPA. Nobody has shown up with the answer because the answer isn't a new system. It's a thin layer above the systems you already trust.

This block describes that layer in plain language — what it is, what it pulls from, what it produces, and what it deliberately is not.

Read this with a pen. If anything looks wrong or missing, mark it. The architecture has to be right before the implementation options on the next page mean anything.

THE PRINCIPLE

Don't replace your systems. Build a layer that *makes them agree.*

Square is good at being Square. Triple Seat is good at being Triple Seat. Conqueror runs your bowling. Embed runs your arcade. None of these need replacing — they need a shared brain above them that reads from each one, classifies what it reads, and produces a single version of the truth.

The layer is read-only first. Nothing changes about how your team rings a sale, books an event, or sells a game card on day one. The layer just listens, normalizes, and reports. Once it's right and you trust it, then it starts writing back — into R365, into your loyalty program, into the daily operator digest.

That order matters. Read first, write second. It's how the work earns trust before it touches anything that matters.

§ 01

The architecture, drawn out

Three layers. Source systems on top, the operating layer in the middle, the things you actually use on the bottom. The layer in the middle is the work.

SYSTEM ARCHITECTURE / READ-ONLY

LAYER 01 / SOURCES — YOUR EXISTING SYSTEMS, UNCHANGED

Square	Triple Seat	Embed	Conqueror	Rex	501 Fund
F&B · CARD	EVENTS	ARCADE	BOWLING	ONLINE	DARTS

LAYER 02 / THE OPERATING LAYER — STAR LANES COMMAND

One *customer record*, one *revenue ledger*, one *source of truth.*

FN · 01

Identity match

Same email, phone, or card token across systems collapses into one customer record — bar tab, game card, lane time, event spend.

FN · 02

Revenue classifier

Every transaction tagged: realized revenue, deposit, deferred, prepaid package, comped consumption, gift card. Automatically.

FN · 03

Event reconciler

Beverage packages, venue rentals, F&B packages — separated from inventory comp checks before they hit the books.

FN · 04

Daily digest

One number for yesterday's revenue, one number for deferred deposits, one list of exceptions for your accountant to review.

LAYER 03 / OUTPUTS — WHAT YOUR TEAM AND YOUR BOOKS ACTUALLY SEE

R365	Loyalty	Operator dash	Multi-unit view
CLEAN ENTRIES · NO REVERSALS	FULL-SPEND CUSTOMER PROFILE	DAILY TRUTH, ONE SCREEN	POLARIS + OSU, ONE REPORT

READ-ONLY AT FIRST

Nothing in your production stack changes on day one. The layer listens, normalizes, and reports. Writing back happens only after the data is trustworthy.

VENDOR-AGNOSTIC

If you swap Hot Schedules for a new HR tool, or migrate Compeat to R365 — the layer doesn't break. It pulls from sources, not from a specific brand.

UNIT-PORTABLE

When OSU opens, you don't rebuild this. You connect a second instance of the same source systems and the layer treats them as Location 02.

§ 02

The same guest, one record

In Block A, this customer's Friday night produced four different versions of the truth. Here's what the same night looks like with the operating layer in place.

CASE STUDY / 02 — THE SAME GUEST, RESOLVED

"A customer walks in, buys two beers at the bar, drops $40 on a game card, bowls a lane for an hour, and books a corporate event for next month with a $1,000 deposit."

/ ONE GUEST · ONE NIGHT · FOUR SYSTEMS · ONE TRUTH

SYSTEM	WHAT IT RECORDS	WHERE IT LANDS	STATUS
Square	Records $18 at the bar and the $1,000 deposit. The layer reads both, attributes them to one customer, and routes the deposit to deferred revenue automatically.	→ CUSTOMER + BOOKS	RESOLVED
Embed	Records the $40 game card sale. The layer matches the email or phone to the same customer record from the bar tab and the booking.	→ SAME RECORD	RESOLVED
Conqueror	Records the lane time. The layer attributes the bowling spend to the same customer profile, with full visit context attached.	→ SAME RECORD	RESOLVED
Triple Seat	Holds the event booking and the $1,000 as a future-dated liability. The layer keeps Triple Seat as the source of truth for events and prevents Square from double-counting.	→ BOOKS, CORRECTLY	RESOLVED
R365	Receives one clean entry: $108 realized F&B + bowling + arcade revenue, $1,000 in deferred event deposits. No journal reversal needed at month-end.	→ BOOKS, AUTOMATICALLY	RESOLVED

THE CUSTOMER SIDE

One person, *one record*, $108 in actual spend tied to a $1,000 future event — the kind of customer your loyalty program should treat differently than a once-a-quarter bowler.

THE ACCOUNTING SIDE

Books reflect *$108 realized, $1,000 deferred* on the day it happens. *No reversal at month-end.* No five-hour weekly cleanup.

§ 03

Three things this has to do, no exceptions

Whatever gets built has to clear all three of these bars on day one. Anything that fails one of them is a different project — and not the one Star Lanes needs.

NON-NEGOTIABLE · 01

Nothing breaks *on day one.*

Read-only deployment. Your team rings transactions the same way. Square, Triple Seat,

NON-NEGOTIABLE · 02

Built for *two locations,* not one.

Every architectural choice gets made for the OSU build, not just Polaris. The day OSU opens, you

NON-NEGOTIABLE · 03

Owned by you, *not the vendor.*

Customer data, revenue ledger, integration code — all live in your environment. If you ever sell, the

Embed, Conqueror operate exactly as they do today. The layer listens — nothing more — until you trust it.

connect a second instance and roll out a multi-location dashboard — you don't rebuild.

buyer gets the operating system. No vendor lock that costs you leverage at the table.

What this is *not.*

Worth being explicit. The layer above is narrow on purpose. These are the things it deliberately doesn't try to be — because trying would dilute the work and double the timeline.

- × Not a replacement for Square, Triple Seat, or any of your POS systems. Those tools stay exactly where they are.
- × Not an AI phone agent. You already heard the negative feedback from UWM rolling that out. I'm not going there.
- × Not a website chatbot. Your agency is handling that on Go High Level. Out of scope here.
- × Not an SEO or AI-search optimization play. You're already doing that work and doing it well.
- × Not a marketing automation engine. Go High Level can keep doing campaigns; this layer just hands it cleaner customer data to work with.
- × Not a one-vendor lock-in. If you change accounting platforms, HR platforms, or POS in the future, the layer adapts. Your sources can change without rebuilding the brain.

§ D

Block D of E

CHOICE

Three Paths *Forward*

Pick the one that matches where Star Lanes actually is.

Three real options. Three different answers to *where Star Lanes is headed* over the next 18 months — not three flavors of the same project.

The question isn't *"what's the right price"* — it's *"how much of the operating system do you want to fix right now."* Each path below answers that question differently.

One is a low-risk way to prove the layer works on a single bleed before committing to more. One is the full single-location fix — the project that pays for itself in the first year. One is built for OSU from day one and protects the three-unit endgame.

None of these include a markup for AI hype, vendor referrals, or hosted-platform fees. Pricing reflects the actual engineering work — scoped, sized, and named so you and I both know exactly what's being built and what's not.

§ 01

The three paths

Each path is a complete project, not a tier. Pick the one that matches where Star Lanes actually is — the one with the right answer to the question at the top of each card.

PATH 01 / THE PILOT

The Proof.

PATH 02 / THE FOUNDATION

The Fix.

PATH 03 / THE TWO-UNIT BUILD

The Endgame.

"Show me it works on something real before I commit to more."

$5,000 ONE PAYMENT

2-week build · No commitment beyond

One bleed, fixed. The event-deposit reconciliation problem from Block B — built read-only against your real data so you can see the layer working before scaling it.

WHAT YOU GET

- Working dashboard against your live Square + Triple Seat data
- Reconciliation report your sister-in-law can use against R365
- One-page write-up of what worked and what scaling looks like

TIMELINE
2 WEEKS

SCOPE
POLARIS ONLY

"Get Polaris running clean before I worry about OSU."

$18,000 2 × $9,000 MONTHLY

6–8 week build · Polaris only

The full operating layer from Block C, deployed at Polaris. Every bleed in Block B addressed. One customer record across systems, clean R365 entries, no more monthly reversal cycle.

WHAT YOU GET

- Unified data layer across all 6 of your revenue systems
- Auto-classified revenue: deposits, deferred, comped, gift card
- Daily operator digest + Square Loyalty bridge with full customer spend

TIMELINE
6–8 WEEKS

SCOPE
POLARIS ONLY

"Build it for OSU from day one. Set up the three-unit exit."

$36,000 3 × $12,000 MONTHLY

10–12 week build · Polaris + OSU-ready

Everything in The Fix, plus the architecture that makes OSU a connection — not a rebuild. Multi-location dashboard from launch. Acquisition-ready reporting structure. The operating system that earns the multiple.

WHAT YOU GET — BEYOND PATH 02

- Multi-tenant architecture — OSU connects in days, not months
- Cross-location loyalty + unit-economics reporting from launch
- Acquisition-readiness data package: clean, auditable, exportable

TIMELINE
10–12 WEEKS

SCOPE
POLARIS + OSU-READY

OPTIONAL · AFTER LAUNCH

Ongoing support — *$750 per month.*

Available after Path 02 or Path 03 goes live. Covers monitoring, small tweaks, and rolling in new use cases as they come up — like adding the OSU integration when it opens, or wiring in a new HR tool when you swap from Hot Schedules.

Not required. The build is the build, and it works without me. This is the line item if you want me on call instead of paying for a new project every time something changes.

Month-to-month. No annual lock-in.

PUNCH LINE

When each path *pays for itself.*

Math against the reconciliation tax from Block B alone — $10,400/year at one location, $20,800/year at two. Doesn't include loyalty program revenue, acquisition multiple impact, or any other upside.

PATH	BUILD COST	ANNUAL RECOVERY	PAYBACK
01 / The Proof	$5,000	~$4,000 (one bleed)	~15 months
02 / The Foundation	**$18,000**	**$10,400 (Polaris)**	**21 months**
03 / The Two-Unit Build	**$36,000**	**$20,800 (Polaris + OSU)**	**21 months**

Payback math is intentionally conservative — it counts only the labor savings already documented in Block B. The real return shows up in (a) a loyalty program built on real customer data, (b) clean financials when a buyer walks in at three units, and (c) the time you stop spending personally on system workarounds. Those numbers don't fit cleanly in this table — but they're where the work earns its keep.

WHAT HAPPENS NEXT

1. You read this with your sister-in-law and Erin. *The accountant and the events director should both have a vote — they live in the bleeds.*

Pick a path, or push back. *Both are useful answers.*

If one of these matches where Star Lanes actually is, tell me and I'll send a project agreement within 48 hours. If none of them quite fit, that's a conversation I'd rather have than a sale that's wrong for the business. Either way, the next move is yours.

2. We get on a 30-minute call. *You tell me what's right, what's wrong, and which path matches what Star Lanes actually needs.*
3. I send a one-page agreement. *Scope, deliverables, timeline, payment terms. Signed both ways before any work starts.*
4. Kickoff within two weeks of signing. *Read-only data access first. Nothing in your stack changes until I've earned the trust to touch it.*

§ E

Block E of E

UPSIDE

The Exit *Math*

$36,000 to protect a $3.6M swing.

Block B put a $20K/year number on the labor tax. That's the visible cost. *This page shows you the bigger one* — the one that shows up the day a buyer walks in at three units.

You said it yourself: three units is what gets Star Lanes acquirable. The Bowlero–Lucky Strike consolidation is happening in real time. Private equity is actively buying multi-unit FEC operators — and consolidation is accelerating, not slowing down.

When a buyer shows up, they're not buying the venue. They're buying the operating system. And the cleaner the operating system, the higher the multiple they'll pay.

This block puts a real number on what dirty data costs at the closing table. The math uses public industry multiples and conservative assumptions. Every input is shown — push back on any of them and the answer redoes itself.

/ THE EXIT-TABLE BLEED

$3.6M

is the swing between a 4× and a 5× multiple at three units.

A BUYER PAYING $14.4M FOR DIRTY BOOKS VERSUS $18M FOR CLEAN ONES IS THE SAME BUSINESS — DIFFERENT OPERATING SYSTEM. THE $36K PATH 03 BUILD IS WHAT CLOSES THE GAP.

§ 01

What buyers are paying right now

EBITDA multiples in the bowling and entertainment-venue space, drawn from 2025–2026 industry data and live listing comps. The range is the first thing a buyer's banker tells them — it's not a secret, and it's not negotiable on the upper end without a reason.

INDUSTRY DATA / 2025–2026

A bowling-anchored entertainment venue trades at *3× to 6× EBITDA* — the question is which end of the range you're on.

Star Lanes is not a small legacy alley. It's a 35,000+ sq ft entertainment-driven venue with corporate events, a VIP room, and multiple revenue centers. That puts the natural multiple in the upper half of the range — but only if the financials hold up under diligence.

TIER 01 / BOTTOM

3×

Small legacy alley

Older bowling-only operator, owner-dependent, dirty books. Often priced closer to real estate or equipment value than a clean EBITDA multiple.

TIER 02 / MIDDLE

3.7×–4.9×

Entertainment-driven venue

Where Star Lanes sits today, based on live ask comps. Modern attractions, F&B, events — but operating system reliant on owner and manual processes.

TIER 03 / TOP

5×–6×+

Multi-unit, clean ops, system-of-record

Where Star Lanes can sit at three units with the operating layer in place. Auditable financials, transferable systems, low owner-dependency.

Sources: Dealstream Industry Rules of Thumb (bowling alleys), Sigma M&A 2025–2026 sale data (5.50× EBITDA average), Midwest Brokers April 2026 live ask comps (3.7×–4.9× for entertainment-driven venues), Verified Market Research 2026 (Bowlero / Lucky Strike consolidation, AI-driven margin expansion to 25%).

§ 02

Two versions of the same business

Same three units, same revenue, same EBITDA. The only difference is what the operating system looks like when a buyer's diligence team opens the hood.

SCENARIO A / WITHOUT THE LAYER

The *discount* case.

"They couldn't verify what we couldn't show them."

EBITDA at 3 units (~$1.2M each)	$3.6M
Multiple applied (mid-range)	4.0×
Diligence-driven adjustments	– deferred deposits
Reconciliation work post-LOI	– 4–6 weeks delay
Walk-away valuation	$14.4M

The buyer's QofE report flags revenue recognition issues. Earnings get "normalized" downward. The multiple gets pinned to mid-range because the data isn't auditable. Every soft number is rounded against you.

SCENARIO B / WITH THE LAYER

The *premium* case.

"Clean books, repeatable ops, transferable system."

EBITDA at 3 units (~$1.2M each)	$3.6M
Multiple applied (top of range)	5.0×
Diligence-driven adjustments	– minimal
Reconciliation work post-LOI	– days, not weeks
Premium valuation	$18.0M

Buyers can see the financials live, in a dashboard. Customer data is owned and transferable. Unit economics are repeatable. The multiple holds at the top of the range because nothing in diligence makes them flinch.

THE VALUATION SWING

$3.6M

A one-turn multiple swing on $3.6M of EBITDA. That's the difference between Scenario A and Scenario B — and it has nothing to do with the venue. It has to do with the operating system underneath it.

COST TO BUILD THE LAYER
$36,000

→

100× RETURN
IF IT SHIFTS THE MULTIPLE BY ONE TURN

§ 03

What buyers actually ask in the data room

These are the five questions every PE buyer or strategic acquirer asks in diligence on a multi-unit operator. The "now" column is what you can answer today. The "after" column is what the operating layer puts in your hand before the buyer walks in.

Q · 01

"Can I see your financials right now — in a dashboard, not a spreadsheet?"

TODAY	AFTER
3 SPREADSHEETS, 2 SYSTEMS, MANUAL RECONCILIATION	ONE DASHBOARD, REAL-TIME, MULTI-LOCATION

Q · 02

"What happens to revenue recognition when the owner steps away?"

TODAY	AFTER
SISTER-IN-LAW HOLDS THE WORKAROUNDS IN HER HEAD	CLASSIFICATION RULES LIVE IN CODE, NOT PEOPLE

Q · 03

"How do I integrate this into our existing portfolio?"

TODAY	AFTER
CUSTOM INTEGRATION PROJECT, $1M+ POST-CLOSE	STANDARD DATA EXPORTS FROM A DOCUMENTED ARCHITECTURE

Q · 04

"Can I trust the numbers — under audit?"

TODAY	AFTER
QOFE FLAGS MULTIPLE NORMALIZATION ADJUSTMENTS	QOFE CONFIRMS — SYSTEM-GENERATED, AUDITABLE

Q · 05

"Who owns the customer data — and can it transfer?"

TODAY	AFTER
FRAGMENTED ACROSS SQUARE, EMBED, TRIPLE SEAT, REX	UNIFIED CUSTOMER DATABASE, OWNED BY THE ENTITY

Q · 06

"What do I have to spend to fix this after closing?"

TODAY	AFTER
$1–2M POST-CLOSE, COMES OUT OF YOUR PRICE	ALREADY DONE. BUYER WALKS IN, LAYER IS RUNNING

*The five-question framework comes from how PE diligence teams actually score deals on multi-unit service operators. The principle is the same across industries: **buyers can't price what they can't verify, so they assume the worst.** The cleaner the operating system, the less they have to assume — and the higher the multiple holds.*

PUNCH LINE

• THE MATH, ONE MORE TIME

$36,000 to protect a *$3.6M swing* at the closing table.

Path 03 is not a $36K decision about reconciliation work. It's a one-turn multiple decision on a future $18M sale. Even at half the swing — half a turn instead of a full one — the math is still 50× return on the build cost.

None of this assumes the venue grows, the EBITDA grows, or the multiple stretches into top-of-range territory. It assumes a normal three-unit Star Lanes selling to a normal buyer at normal industry multiples. Everything beyond that is upside.

The audit cost is rounding error against the exit math. The only question is whether you want to be Scenario A or Scenario B when a buyer walks in.

BUILD COST VS. EXIT-TABLE SWING

$36,000 → $3,600,000

A NOTE ON THE MATH

Everything on this page is built from public industry data and conservative assumptions about Star Lanes' future EBITDA at three units. The $1.2M per-unit EBITDA figure is illustrative — it sits within the range of comparable bowling-anchored entertainment venues but isn't drawn from your books. The multiple range (3×–6×) is sourced from 2025–2026 industry valuation data. The point isn't the precise dollar amount. The point is the relationship — that a one-turn multiple swing on a multi-unit FEC operator dwarfs anything you'd spend on the operating layer that prevents the swing in the first place. If your actual EBITDA at three units lands at $1.5M or $2M, the swing gets bigger, not smaller.

● WHAT HAPPENS NEXT

Pick a path, or push back. *Both are useful answers.*

If one of the three paths in Block D matches where Star Lanes actually is, tell me and I'll send a project agreement within 48 hours. If none of them quite fit, that's a conversation I'd rather have than a sale that's wrong for the business.

Either way, the next move is yours. Read this with your sister-in-law and Erin. The accountant and the events director both have a vote — they live in the bleeds I've described above. Then call me, text me, or email me whenever you're ready.

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April 2026

Pricing valid through June 30, 2026